LONER_COMPANION

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Loner 4e: Companion

Introduction

What This Book Is

Loner began as a ten-page document: a personal workflow assembled from other people's brilliant ideas. The questions that came after it, from players who wanted to understand not just the rules but the thinking behind them, eventually became this Companion. The full story is in Appendix A.

The Core Rules answer *how*. This book answers *why*.

The Core Rules give you authoritative procedures: framing scenes, closing scenes, consulting the oracle, resolving conflicts, tracking the world after an adventure. If you want to know what to do and when, the Core Rules are your reference.

This Companion gives you what the Core Rules do not have space for: the philosophy behind the procedures, the judgment calls that arise when applying them, and the practical reading of what the rules actually ask of you in specific situations.

The three ideas at the center of *Loner*, Fiction First, Emergent Narrative, and Fictional Positioning, are named in the Core Rules. This book explores what they mean when the

fiction gets complicated: how tags earn their place and lose it, how conditions clear and when they should not, how scars and losses count as advancement just as much as skills gained, how NPCs and the world move between scenes without you, and how the oracle produces a story neither you nor it could have scripted in advance.

The fourth edition of *Loner* added new procedures and two optional modules to the core loop. This Companion covers all of them: where they came from, how to apply them, and what good judgment looks like when the rules leave the rest to you.

Who This Book Is For

If you have read the Core Rules and want more: this is for you. You know how a roll works; now you want to know how to think about the system when the answers are not obvious.

If you are new to *Loner*: read the Core Rules first, then come back here. Everything in this book assumes you know what the oracle is, what a tag does, and how a scene opens and closes.

Solo play often feels awkward before it feels right. The Oracle gives answers you have to interpret yourself, the story goes directions you did not plan, and there is no one else in the room to confirm you are reading things correctly. That discomfort is normal and it passes. This book will help you understand why the system is built the way it is, which makes those judgment calls easier.

How to Use It

Read it alongside play. The chapters follow the shape of the Core Rules: setup, mechanics, narrative, and long-term play.

Each section expands the corresponding procedure without replacing it.

Zahra Nakajima appears throughout, the same protagonist from the Core Rules examples. Following her across multiple sections lets you see how the same fictional thread looks from different angles: from the mechanics of a specific roll, to the judgment behind it, to what it means for who she is becoming.

The story of how *Loner* was built, where it came from and what it was assembled from, is in Appendix A.

The Core of Loner: Story-Driven Play

Loner keeps mechanics in service of story. Three concepts carry most of the weight. Each has its own section here, but in practice they work together constantly.

Fiction First: Story Takes the Lead

Loner uses tags instead of numerical stats because the question you should be asking is “does this make sense for who this character is?” not “do I have the right number?” Tags describe what is true about a character. That truth licenses certain actions and closes off others before a die is rolled.

A character with *Skilled Locksmith* can attempt to pick a lock. A character without any relevant tag probably cannot,

or faces a much harder ask. The tag is a claim about the fiction. When the claim is relevant, the Oracle reflects that. When it is not, the dice run without it.

Emergent Narrative: Discover the Story as You Go

Loner has no preset plot. The story comes from the collision between what your protagonist wants and what the Oracle reveals. You ask a question, the dice answer it, and you interpret that answer in the context of what is already true. Do that enough times and a story appears that neither you nor the Oracle could have scripted in advance.

The Oracle's yes-no structure matters here. It forces you to commit to a specific question, which means committing to a specific expectation. When the answer subverts that expectation, the story goes somewhere new. That is the mechanism.

This is what separates *Loner* from creative writing and from directed storytelling. In creative writing, you decide what happens. In *Loner*, the Oracle and Twist Counter exist specifically to take that decision out of your hands. The outcome of a roll isn't what you choose; it's what happens. Your role is to respond.

A **No, and** when you needed a **Yes** doesn't end the story; it forces you to adapt. The protagonist's plan fails, the situation worsens, and you discover what your character does when things go wrong. You didn't write that. The system generated it, and you inhabited it.

Over time, this process produces a story that surprises you, one you couldn't have scripted because you didn't control every outcome. The arc becomes visible when you look back, not when you look forward.

Fictional Positioning: Your Character in Context

Fictional positioning is the principle that what your character can attempt depends on where they stand in the story, not on what the player wants to happen. Before asking the Oracle anything, ask: does this action follow from who my character is and what the situation has established?

A character tagged *Skilled Locksmith* can try the door. A character tagged *Afraid of Heights* faces a real obstacle on a rooftop, not just a narrative flavour. A *Grizzled Soldier* might read military formations at a glance; the same character probably cannot talk their way past a corporate checkpoint without a relevant social skill. Tags and the scene's established facts are both inputs. Both matter before the dice come out.

What Drives Loner: The Design Principles

Minimalism and Portability

You need just a few basics to play: six-sided dice for resolving challenges, writing tools for notes and tracking, and a character sheet for tags and details. Optional materials can add depth, but the essentials remain light.

Rules-Light Mechanics

The mechanics of *Loner* are intentionally minimal, but minimal is not the same as simple. Rules-light means the system trusts you to fill in what it leaves out. Each mechanic is less a directive and more a question: Tags ask what you believe about your character right now. The Oracle asks what you're willing to risk not knowing. Scene types ask what's happening on the surface and what's being avoided underneath.

These aren't lightweight prompts. They're designed to hold whatever weight you bring to them. The brevity is purposeful: fewer rules means each element carries more responsibility. A single concept phrase in *Loner* does the work that a character class, skill list, and backstory table might do in another game. The constraint is part of the design.

In practice, this means the game doesn't run itself. It asks for your attention and your willingness to engage with ambiguity. You won't find prewritten scenes or detailed guidance for every situation. You'll find structures, and you'll fill them with something specific to your character and your fiction. The resolution system is simple: two six-sided dice, one for Chance and one for Risk, producing a yes-or-no answer. The questions you ask with it are not simple at all.

Tag-Based Descriptions

Instead of numerical stats, *Loner* uses *tags*: descriptive phrases that capture essential traits, skills, and characteristics. Tags name what your character is naturally good at, what they struggle with, and how they move through the world. A tag is a claim, not a rating, so the decision it produces comes from the story rather than a spreadsheet.

Generic Yet Focused Gameplay

Loner can adapt to any setting, but it is not trying to be a one-size-fits-all RPG. It is built for quick resolution and storytelling, not tactical depth or simulation, which is why it works as well for a fantasy dungeon as it does for a noir stakeout. What travels between settings is not the fiction but the discipline underneath it: simplicity, emergent storytelling, fictional positioning. Change the genre and the tags change; the discipline doesn't.

Everything Is a Character

One of the most flexible ideas in *Loner* is that anything that matters to the story can be treated as a **character**: even if it's not a person. This is a way to unify how you describe and interact with the elements of your world.

When something matters in the fiction, when it exerts pressure on the protagonist, presents choices, or evolves over time, it deserves the same descriptive clarity you'd give a named character. This includes not just allies and rivals, but factions, vehicles, artificial intelligences, locations, monsters, magical items, and more.

You don't need to create a separate system for vehicles or relics or ghost towns, you just describe them with **tags**. You

assign them a **concept**. If relevant, you give them **gear** or a **frailty**. Most of the time, that's enough.

These "non-human characters" don't need a Goal or Motive, unless the fiction demands it. You're free to imagine a sentient sword with a personal agenda or a rogue satellite with a vendetta, but it's just as valid to keep them lean and functional.

📌 Example: Treating a Ship as a Character

Let's say Zahra's starship, the *Century Skylark*, is central to the adventure. Instead of inventing a ship system, you write:

- **Concept**: *Spacecraft in bad shape*
- **Skills**: *Hyperjump Drive, Camouflage Circuits*
- **Frailty:** *Midlife Courier*
- **Gear**: *Stealth Hull Mod, Emergency Override Key*
- **Luck**: 6

Now the ship can come under pressure: its frailty can complicate things; its tags can grant advantages when appropriate. You might even track **conditions** like *Low Fuel* or *Internal Lockdown*. You narrate its involvement the same way you would for a loyal companion or an unpredictable contact.

Example: Treating a Faction as a Character

The Leton Corporation may be a looming presence, but that doesn't mean you need an org chart. You define them with:

- **Concept**: *Tech Monopoly with a Smile*
- **Skills**: *Opaque Ethics, Total Market Surveillance*
- **Frailty**: *Shareholder Anxiety*

- **Gear**: *Legal Armory, Encrypted Vaults*

Now, any interaction with Leton, from negotiation to infiltration, has fictional weight. You don't track numbers or stat blocks. You follow narrative logic, anchored by specific descriptors.

This is what *Loner* means by minimalist. You don't reduce complexity. You reduce friction.

If it has story gravity, give it tags. If it might break, give it a frailty. If it might help, give it gear. And if it doesn't do any of those things? You don't need to stat it at all.

The Promotion Rule

A simple test for when to write a character sheet:

- **Matters once** → keep it as plain tags.
- **Keeps showing up, or actively pushes back** → promote it to a character and play it by the same rules.

Most factions are just world tags, *Under Surveillance*, *Wanted Everywhere*, until they become an active opponent. Most locations are just atmosphere until they resist, reward, or remember. When that threshold is crossed, give them a sheet.

📌 Example: A Faction as Active Opponent

Helios Biotech

- Concept: Predatory biotech conglomerate
- Skills: Corporate surveillance net; Legal intimidation
- Frailty: Leaky infosec
- Gear: Black-bag contractors; Front clinics
- Goal: Corner the market on genetic patents

- Motive: Profit through control of life itself
- Nemesis: Activist networks exposing corporate crimes

Most of the time, Helios is just tags giving the protagonist trouble. When they start actively coming after her, roll against their Skills like any other character.

📌 Example: A Cursed Location

The Fen Of Bones

- Concept: Fog-choked burial ground
- Skills: Raise uneasy dead; Whispering dread
- Frailty: Bound by consecrated rites
- Gear: Bone reliquary; Weathered ward-stones

Exorcising the Fen is a conflict: each oracle success flips or erases one of its hostile tags until the place is cleansed. New tags like *Consecrated Ground* replace the old ones. Failures stick conditions on the protagonist or escalate the site.

Preparing for Your Adventure

Choosing a Genre or Setting

Every *Loner* adventure begins by choosing a genre or setting: the world that defines the tone, themes, and atmos-

phere your protagonist will move through. This decision shapes the kinds of challenges they will face and the tags that will make sense for them.

Exploring Familiar or Uncharted Worlds

You might start with a familiar setting: something from a book, a TV series, or an RPG world you already know. This gives you a running start because the world's logic is already in your head.

Or you might want something new. *Loner* works with any genre, and hybrid combinations, noir mixed with medieval fantasy, science fiction crossed with horror, are perfectly viable. The system does not care what the world looks like. It only needs tags and questions.

Playing with Tropes and Adventure Packs

If you want a starting point, draw on classic tropes or one of the **Adventure Packs** available for the *Loner* system. Tropes like the "reluctant hero," "haunted location," or "lost artifact" give you genre anchors without locking in a plot.

You can roll for a few random tropes and let them shape your setup, or use an Adventure Pack to get a quick-start framework with suggested tags and story hooks. Either way, the goal is the same: get enough of a premise to ask a first question and start.

Why There Is No Default Setting

Most RPGs ask you to learn a setting first, then fit your character into it. *Loner* reverses this order. You start with a character concept and a genre vibe, and the world takes shape in response to what the story demands. This is the design.

A fixed default setting would impose a frame the story has to fit into. Without one, the frame bends around the story. You are not working inside someone else's established canon, which means no lore to memorize, no continuity to protect, and no wrong answers about what the world contains. The world exists only as far as the fiction needs it to, and it expands when your protagonist pushes against it.

This also means the world you build through play is specific in the way that matters: it was shaped by actual events, not inherited from a sourcebook. A location that appeared because the Oracle said yes carries weight that a location described in advance does not.

📌 Example: Zahra's adventure is set in a "cyberpunk dystopia"

> Corporate dominance, underground movements, advanced-but-decadent technology. The Leton Corporation controls the planet's tech supply; its facilities are guarded by drones and scanners. This setting immediately suggests the tags that will matter: stealth, street knowledge, corporate access. A post-apocalyptic wasteland or space opera would produce a different Zahra and a different set of questions, because the world's logic determines what's possible.

Creating Your Protagonist

The Protagonist's traits, goals, and background determine what questions you ask, which tags matter, and how the Oracle's answers land.

The Power of a Strong Concept

A strong concept is a short phrase that captures who your protagonist is, blending personality and role into a single image. A concept like *Witty Street Cat* or *Cunning Alchemist* tells you what your character can do and hints at how they see the world.

📌 Example: Zahra's concept is "Witty Street Cat"

> Resourceful, quick-witted, at home in urban shadows. The phrase tells you how she survives and how she sees herself: a lone survivor, not a hero. Before a single tag is written, the concept already answers the question: *what kind of person does this story follow?*

Defining Traits with Tags

Three tags do the work of capturing your protagonist: what they're good at, what fails them, and what they carry. None of them lock in a number.

- **Skills**: Pick two. Not "strong" or "clever," but something with a story already folded into it: an *Engine Whisperer* or a *Sharp-Eyed Tracker* tells you where the character has been, not just what they can do.
- **Frailty**: A vulnerability or flaw, physical, emotional, or social, that costs them something: *Quick to Anger*, *Easily Distracted*.
- **Gear**: The items worth naming, because everyday equipment is already assumed. An *Old Compass* or a *Hacker's Toolkit* earns its place on the sheet by mattering to the story, not by being useful.

Tags don't add mechanical bonuses; they license or complicate an approach.

📌 Example: Zahra's tags built from her concept

- *Skills*: **Streetwise** (reads people and places at a glance); **Nimble** (moves with feline agility, squeezes through tight spaces)
- *Frailty*: **Merciful** (hesitates to cause harm; opponents can exploit this)
- *Gear*: **Knife** (a last resort, always within reach); **Low O2 Supplement** (carries the environmental crisis everywhere she goes)

The Sheet Is Not a Score

The design question is not "how many tags does this character have?" but "which tags capture what makes this character matter in any scene I'm likely to play?"

Tags are situational signposts. At any given scene, one or two apply. The rest are inert. A sheet with twenty tags doesn't play richer than one with six well-chosen tags. It plays noisier. The sheet describes who this character is now, not the legend they might become. Tags do evolve over time: some are earned through play, some are rewritten when the fiction changes, some are crossed out entirely. But that evolution is the story reshaping the character, not accumulation toward a more powerful build.

This matters most when you're bringing an established fictional archetype to the table. The instinct is to transcribe every documented ability into tags: each skill listed in the source, each piece of equipment mentioned, each technique demonstrated. That's a category error. Tags aren't a stat block. They only do something when they bear directly on the fictional moment at hand.

Consider a character like Sherlock Holmes. He is a brilliant detective, an expert boxer, a master of disguise, a chemist, a violinist, an authority on criminal history, and a practitioner of baritsu. Transcribed faithfully, that's eight tags before you've written a frailty. But every scene you're likely to play calls on at most two of these. The rest sit unused.

📌 Example: Sherlock Holmes

- Concept: Brilliant Consulting Detective
- Skills: The Science of Deduction; Relentless Analytical Focus
- Frailty: Contempt for the Ordinary (his disdain for conventional thinking alienates allies and makes him underestimate people he dismisses)
- Gear: Disguise Kit; London Street Knowledge
- Goal: Solve what no one else can
- Motive: Boredom is worse than death
- Nemesis: Professor Moriarty
- Luck: 6

That sheet handles every Holmes scene. Crime scene analysis: *The Science of Deduction*, Advantage. A chase through London streets: *London Street Knowledge* covers the terrain. Infiltrating a suspect's household: *Disguise Kit* and the Concept cover the implicit competence. A confrontation where he alienates a witness or underestimates Watson: *Contempt for the Ordinary* is right there.

The fact that he boxes, plays violin, and knows baritsu isn't absent from the fiction. It is subsumed in the Concept and the Skills. He is a brilliant consulting detective who relies on relentless analytical focus. Everything else follows from that.

Wiki-porting an ability list into tags treats tags like a skill tree. It maps coverage, not character. The sheet above is Holmes. Every scene you play will feel like Holmes. That's the test.

Goals, Motives, and Nemesis

These elements give your protagonist direction and stakes:

- **Goal**: What is your protagonist working toward? A clear goal keeps the story moving. Goals like *Reclaim a Lost Artifact*, *Uncover a Hidden Conspiracy,* or *Save Their Hometown* give purpose to every scene they enter.
- **Motive**: This is the "why" behind the goal: the reason they keep going when things get hard. Redemption, revenge, justice, obligation. Motives give weight to decisions and distinguish a protagonist from a placeholder.
- **Nemesis**: The force working against them. This could be an individual, an organization, or a hostile environment. A defined nemesis keeps the opposition concrete and the stakes visible.

With a strong concept, specific tags, and a clear goal, your protagonist is ready to start. Everything else can be discovered through play.

📌 Example: Zahra's framework

- *Goal*: Obtain unknown technology that could reverse atmospheric collapse
- *Motive*: Save her planet; she grew up watching the air quality fall and feels personally responsible for acting
- *Nemesis*: The Naturalist Order, which believes failing ecosystems should collapse without intervention and will stop anyone who tries to prevent it

Expanding the World

The NPCs, organizations, locations, and events around your protagonist give the fiction texture and stakes. Building these out before play, even briefly, means you have something to draw on when the Oracle takes the story somewhere unexpected.

Crafting NPCs and Organizations

NPCs and organizations give your protagonist relationships to test, allies to rely on, and opponents to work against.

- **NPCs**: A strong concept and a few descriptive tags are enough. *Tobias, Loyal Informant* or *Selene, Ambitious Rival* already tells you the personality, the loyalty, and where the friction will come from.
- **Organizations**: Guilds, agencies, factions, whatever scale the setting supports. Give the organization a goal and a motive the same way you would a character, and it stops being scenery. *The Naturalist Order* resisting technological progress is a source of friction only because it wants something specific, not because "faction" is a genre requirement.

Motivations that intersect with your protagonist's goal are what make NPCs and organizations useful. When their interests cross, the story generates its own pressure without you having to invent conflict.

📌 **Example: Zahra's supporting cast**

- *Tobias Wethern, Loyal Informant*: mentor, former data broker, father figure. Tags: **Resourceful**, **Protective**. His loyalty is real; his full agenda is not always transparent.

- *Melina Reade, Expert Hacker*: close ally with deep underground tech connections. Tags: **Connected**, **Innovative**. Provides access to encrypted systems and hidden networks.
- *The Naturalist Order*: secretive, ideologically rigid, well-organized. Tags: **Ruthless**, **Eco-Purist**. Operatives can infiltrate government and corporate ranks.
- *Leton Corporation*: tech monopoly, motivated purely by profit. Tags: **Greedy**, **Well-Connected**. Not a direct enemy, but their interests consistently block Zahra's.

Defining Locations and Events

Locations and events are the stage and the backstory. A handful, sketched before play, give you something to draw on when the Oracle sends the story somewhere you didn't plan.

- **Locations**: Detail them as much as their importance warrants, nothing more. *The Smoke-Filled Alley* or *The Shattered Observatory* already tells you what might happen there; you don't need a paragraph of description to earn the name.
- **Events**: Something sweeping, like *The Fall of the Crimson Empire*, or something recent, like *The Disappearance of Key Scientists*. Either kind gives NPCs a reason for what they want and gives the story a hook to pull on later.

An Oracle answer lands harder when it complicates something specific: a named vault, a named betrayal, not a generic "the city" or "the past." That's what this groundwork buys you.

📌 Example: Zahra's world, sketched before play begins

Locations:

- *The Smog-Drenched Markets*: Zahra's home ground. Black-market goods, oxygen filters, rumors traded as currency. Vital for gathering intel; dangerous for everyone.
- *Leton Corporation Vault*: heavily guarded facility on the city's edge, patrolled by AI drones. Her ultimate target.
- *The Ruined Biodome*: condemned atmospheric research site, now a scavenger haunt. A stark reminder of what happens when the technology fails.

Events:

- *The Atmospheric Collapse*: the chain reaction of environmental neglect that created Zahra's mission. Shapes every layer of society, from street vendors to corporate executives.
- *The Scientist Exodus*: five years ago, environmental researchers vanished. Rumored to have joined the Naturalist Order, taking crucial data with them. If Zahra can find them, she might find answers.

From Premise to First Scene

You have a protagonist, a setting, and a goal. That's a premise: but it isn't play yet. There's a gap between "I know what this story is about" and "I am in the first scene," and new players often stall here, unsure what the first move is.

A **first-scene checklist**, six questions borrowed from the journalist's 5W+H, helps bridge this. (It is a different tool from the Core Rules' *Build the Setup* table, which rolls a premise

at random; this checklist articulates one you already have.) Before you open the scene, answer each question briefly:

- **Who** is involved besides your protagonist at the start?
- **What** is the immediate situation: what's already happening?
- **When** and **Where** does the story open?
- **Why** is your protagonist here right now, not tomorrow?
- **How** does tension enter the first moment?

You don't need detailed answers, a phrase for each is enough. *Zahra is at the dockside warehouse (Where/When) because her contact went silent two days ago (Why). A guard she doesn't recognize is at the door (Who/What). The lights inside are off (How).* That's a scene. Now ask the Oracle your first question.

If the checklist still feels blank, fall back to the protagonist's Goal. Ask: *Where does my protagonist have to be right now to make progress on their Goal?* Put them there, add one complication, and begin.

One caution: the first scene doesn't need to establish the whole story. Its only job is to put your protagonist in motion. Let everything else emerge.

The Mechanics of Play

Understanding Tags and Descriptors

Tags and descriptors do the work that stats do in other games: they capture what's true about a character, a scene, or an object, in a phrase instead of a number.

Types of Tags: Traits, Details, Conditions

The Core Rules sort tags into three categories: **Traits** (what a character is), **Details** (what a scene or place is), and **Conditions** (temporary states imposed by events). The useful insight behind the taxonomy is lifespan. Traits change slowly, through growth. Details last as long as the scene or location stays in play. Conditions arrive with their end already implied: a wound heals, a reputation fades, a hunt ends. When you write a tag, knowing which kind it is tells you how and when it will leave the sheet.

Using Tags to Shape the Fiction

Tags are interpretive, not numerical: you decide, scene by scene, whether one applies, and nothing forces the question in advance.

An *Agile* trait offers an **advantage** on a climbing challenge because climbing is what it's for. An *Exhausted* condition works the other way, adding **disadvantage** to the same kind of action. Neither tag imposes a hard limit; both hand the fiction a lean in one direction, and the outcome follows from what's actually true of the character in that moment.

Scene Structure and Flow

The story moves one scene at a time, each one a small, self-contained chapter that has to advance the situation and add information; nothing is filler. How you open and guide a scene sets its pacing and tone. How to use each scene type well (Dramatic, Quiet, and Meanwhile) is covered in depth in "Managing Pace and Tension."

Starting Scenes: Framed or In Motion?

The Core Rules give two openings: drop straight into a **Dramatic Scene** mid-action, or **Build the Setup** with the 5W+H table before the first roll. The first is for discovering the story as you play; the second is for knowing the stakes before you commit. They blend well: frame the mission, then open in the middle of it going sideways.

The first-scene checklist in "From Premise to First Scene" is a third tool with a different shape: not a random table, but six questions for bridging a premise you already have into a playable opening moment.

Starting Scenes with Purpose

A scene without a purpose drifts. Even a purpose as plain as "What's waiting in this room?" is enough, because it ties the scene to your protagonist's goals and gives you somewhere to point the first question.

1. **Set a Goal**: What is your protagonist trying to get out of this scene? A clue, a negotiation, an exit. Name it, and you'll know what success or failure looks like when it arrives.
2. **Ask Key Questions**: "Is the room as empty as it looks?" "Does the contact show up on time?" These aren't decoration; they're where you'll consult the Oracle.

3. **Define the Scene's Mood**: Tense, quiet, suspenseful, whatever it is, decide before you roll. Unsure? Roll on the Scene Transition table for a read on the register: *Dramatic*, *Quiet*, or *Meanwhile*.

Goal, question, and mood, decided before the first roll, is what makes an Oracle answer land as something rather than nothing.

Establishing the Scene Before You Roll

The Core Rules give you three questions to answer before a scene opens: *Where* is the protagonist and what does it feel like, *Who* is present or likely to arrive, and *What* does the protagonist intend here. Answer all three, without rolling, using what the fiction has already established. Only ask the Oracle a framing question if something is genuinely uncertain, and let that answer set the stage before the scene begins.

In practice, players skip this step most often mid-campaign, when the next scene feels like it should just follow automatically from the last. It rarely does. Rolling without a clear picture of the situation leads to oracle answers that are hard to interpret, a **Yes, but...** result means nothing if you don't know what a Yes would even look like.

The three questions also serve as a filter. If you can't answer *What does the protagonist intend here?*, the scene probably isn't ready to open yet, you're still in transition. If you can't answer *Who is present?*, you haven't thought through the implications of where the story left off. These gaps are worth noticing before you roll, not after.

One addition worth making: note what the protagonist *knows* versus what's *actually true*. The previous scene may have left information on the table, or an NPC's tag may

have shifted since they last appeared. That gap, between assumed and actual, is often where the first good oracle question lives.

Keeping the Action Moving

Once you're in the scene, three moves keep it from stalling:

1. **Identify Expectations and Challenges**: Know what your protagonist expects, given their traits and the situation, before you ask the Oracle anything. That expectation is what a Yes or No will actually answer.
2. **Let the Oracle Drive Forward**: A **but...** or **and...** is a complication worth following, not smoothing over. Ask what it does to your protagonist's goal, then move.
3. **Transition to the Next Scene**: Once the scene's purpose is resolved, roll the Scene Transition and let it decide what comes next.

Each scene follows from the last only if you let the Oracle's answers change something before you move to the next one.

The Core Rules formalize the opening and closing of scenes into two brief procedures: **Framing a Scene** (establish where, who, and what before you roll anything) and **Closing a Scene** (three conditions that end a scene cleanly, plus an oracle fallback when you're unsure). These procedures work exactly as described above: the formal rules simply give you a checklist to fall back on when the story is moving fast.

Making Decisions Through the Oracle

The Oracle is how you test the story against reality: an uncertain outcome gets a simple answer, and chance, character, and setting combine to produce a result you didn't plan.

What the Oracle Actually Does

Before working with the Oracle's mechanics, it's worth understanding what it is actually for. The Oracle doesn't tell you what happens. It tells you whether what you hoped would happen did happen, and at what cost. You bring the question; the dice answer it; you interpret that answer in the light of everything the fiction has already established. That interpretation is where the game lives.

This means consulting the Oracle requires a particular stance: you have to be willing to be wrong about what happens next. If you already know the answer before you roll, the roll is theater. The Oracle only does its work when the outcome matters and surprises you. Solo play at its best is not authored in advance. It is discovered through the dialogue between what you expect and what the dice reveal.

The Oracle's six results each carry emotional weight. A **Yes, but** is uneasy success: you got what you wanted, and it cost something. A **No, and** is collapse with consequences: not only did the attempt fail, but the situation worsened. Each result asks you to inhabit the character's position and ask what this answer means, right now, in this specific scene. The Oracle gives the event. Your tags and established fiction give it resonance.

Crafting Effective Closed Questions

The Oracle works best with closed questions: ones a straightforward yes or no can actually answer.

1. **Keep it Specific and Focused**: "Does the protagonist escape unharmed?" is too much question for one roll. Break it down: "Does the guard notice the protagonist?" then "Does the protagonist find an unlocked exit?" Smaller

questions let the situation unfold in steps you can actually interpret.

2. **Anchor Questions in Context**: A question grounded in the scene, the goal, and the character's tags gives you an answer you can read. "Does their stealth help them stay hidden?" is interpretable in a way "Do they succeed?" isn't, because it's tied to something specific the character has.
3. **Let the Oracle Surprise You**: Don't frame a question so that either answer stops the story. Ask it so both outcomes open a new possibility, even when the answer isn't what the protagonist hoped for.
4. **Orient Toward the Best Outcome**: Phrase the question from the protagonist's perspective, so *Yes, and...* is always the best possible result. "Does Zahra slip past undetected?" runs best-to-worst; "Is there a guard waiting?" inverts it, so *Yes, and...* becomes the worst possible news. Get the orientation right and the whole range of Oracle results lands in the order it should.

Rolling Dice: Chance and Risk

Each Oracle question is answered by rolling two six-sided dice, one for **Chance** and one for **Risk**. The full procedure lives in the Core Rules: the higher die gives Yes or No, matched low dice add a *but...*, matched high dice add an *and...*, and equal dice give *Yes, but...* plus a point on the Twist Counter. The steps are in the Core Rules and won't be restated here; what matters is what the structure does.

The two dice embody the two sides of every question: what the protagonist brings, and what the world puts in the way. Reading them against each other keeps every answer rela-

tional. Success is never just “you are good at this”; it is “you were better than the resistance this time.”

Advantage and Disadvantage: Adding Depth to Actions

Loner uses **Advantage** and **Disadvantage** to reflect how the protagonist’s traits, conditions, and surroundings affect their actions. The mechanics are in the Core Rules: an extra Chance Die or Risk Die, keep the highest of the pair, read the result from the kept dice only. The design point is that this is the *entire* mechanical footprint of a tag. Tags never add numbers; they tilt the odds once, in one direction, and then get out of the way. That single, capped shift is what lets the fiction decide everything else.

Closed questions, the Oracle’s dice mechanics, and the Advantage/Disadvantage system are the complete toolkit.

Resolving a Situation: One Roll or Many?

When you face a risky action or dramatic moment, you can resolve it in different ways depending on how much detail and pacing you want:

- **Single Roll** Ask one yes/no question. A single result gives you a full answer. *Does the agent slip past the guards undetected?* Quick, clean, and perfect for fast-moving scenes.
- **Multiple Rolls** Break the situation into smaller beats. *“Does she find a place to hide?” → “Can she stay silent?”* This keeps the tension high and gives space for twists.
- **Harm & Luck** For extended conflict: physical or otherwise, track outcomes over time. The Luck score goes down when the protagonist takes hits, and scenes become grittier and more tactical. Best used for fights, duels, pursuits, or dangerous negotiations.

Use the approach that fits your scene's intensity. A conversation might resolve with one roll. A final confrontation might deserve a full Luck-based blow-by-blow.

Interpreting Oracle Responses

The Oracle provides an answer; you do the work of interpreting it. A **and...** or **but...** modifier is a prompt that something else is also true, and connecting that something to the scene is your job, not the dice's.

Reading the Modifiers

The six results and their outcomes are defined in the Core Rules. What the table cannot tell you is weight. An **and...** extends the direction the answer already points; a **but...** bends it. A **Yes, but...** hands you success and a new problem in the same breath; a **No, but...** closes the door and leaves a crack. Treat every modifier as an invitation to add something specific to the scene, not as a fixed quantity of good or bad fortune.

Reading a Plain Yes or No

The confusion players report almost never lands on **Yes, but...** or **No, and...**. Those come with built-in instructions. It lands on the plain result, because nothing tells you what to do with it.

A plain Yes or No isn't an empty roll. It's the Oracle telling you nothing *extra* is true. Resist the urge to manufacture a complication because the moment feels like it deserves one. If the dice didn't ask for it, don't add it.

Yes means the fiction moves exactly the direction the question pointed. Narrate the expected outcome and move to the next beat. This is the fastest result in the game specifically because it needs no invention.

No means it doesn't. The trap is treating No as a wall instead of a redirect. Don't just say "no" and stall, ask what the world looks like now that this path is closed. A guard doesn't just fail to notice nothing, ask what he's doing instead.

📌 Example: Zahra tries the side door

> **Yes...** → *It's unlocked. She's through.* **No...** → *Locked tight. Down the hall, she hears the guard's radio crackle.*

The second line isn't a complication bolted on, it's just what else is true in the scene. A plain No doesn't earn a twist, but the fiction around it didn't stop existing while you rolled.

Equal Dice and the Twist Counter

Equal dice give **Yes, but...** and add 1 to the Twist Counter; at 3, a Twist fires, you roll on the Twist Table, and the counter resets. The procedure is in the Core Rules. The design intent behind the pairing is worth sitting with: the protagonist gets what they wanted, at a cost, and the story banks a little instability for later. Doubles are the system reminding you that smooth sailing is borrowed time. When the counter sits at 2, let that pressure leak into your narration before the mechanics make it real.

Handling Ambiguous Answers

The procedure is in the Core Rules: reframe the answer, ask one open-ended question if you are still stuck, default to **Yes, but...** as a last resort, and treat three follow-up questions as the ceiling. The judgment behind it: ambiguity is almost always a question problem, not an answer problem. If a result will not resolve, the question was probably compound, abstract, or about something the scene had not yet estab-

lished. Trust your first reading, keep the story moving, and let the fiction carry the rest.

When the Oracle Keeps Saying No

A single No is a roadblock. Two in a row is bad luck. Three or more consecutive No results are a pattern: and patterns mean something.

When the Oracle repeatedly denies your protagonist, resist the urge to treat each result in isolation: a fresh question, a fresh roll, a fresh nothing. Instead, step back and ask what the fiction is telling you. A string of failures is not random noise; it is the narrative gathering pressure. Something is working against your protagonist harder than a single obstacle would explain.

This is a moment to name what that is. Is the environment hostile in a way you haven't fully acknowledged? Is someone, or something, actively working to stop them? Is your protagonist pursuing the wrong approach, or the wrong goal entirely? Let the accumulation of No results function as a signal that the situation has shifted, not just that they've had bad luck.

You don't need a new mechanic to handle this. Simply hold the weight of the streak in your narration. The third No doesn't just mean the lock won't open, it means the corridor is filling with smoke and the situation is becoming desperate. The story is escalating whether you roll a twist or not. Let it.

📌 Example: The Bad Guy Isn't There

> **Question:** *Is the antagonist behind this door?* **Oracle: No, and...**

A **No** here doesn't have to mean a dead end. Consider scale:

- **No** (plain): He's not there: but signs suggest he was here recently. Bad intelligence, or he stepped out. A follow-up question can clarify.
- **No, and...**: He's not there, the trail is cold, and the building is now compromised. Pull back; your clue source may have been unreliable or even in his pocket.

If you find yourself stuck after a plain No, the problem is usually the question, not the oracle. "Is he here?" is a closed door. "What does this room tell me about where he went?" opens the story back up.

If a line of inquiry collapses entirely: not just a No but a structural dead end where there is nothing left to pursue, the **Dead Ends** procedure applies.

Dead Ends

A dead end is a structural collapse in the path forward, not a failed roll: a lead gone cold, a contact gone, a line of inquiry with nothing left to act on. The Core Rules give the procedure: stop questioning the closed path, ask *Does something or someone point toward a new way forward?*, and reframe based on the answer.

What matters here is what the procedure implies about consecutive dead ends. If the reframe question fails twice on the same thread, the story is not telling you to try harder; it is telling you the investigation itself rests on a wrong assumption. The approach is blocked, not just the angle. That realization is information, and often the most interesting kind: the moment the protagonist discovers they have been asking the wrong question is a scene in its own right.

Embracing the Emergent Narrative

Letting the Story Unfold

Loner's emergent narrative grows from your protagonist's actions, the Oracle's answers, and whatever complications arise. No two sessions run the same way because no two sequences of Oracle answers are the same.

There is a useful distinction here between *plot-driven* and *procedure-enabled* play. Plot-driven play starts with a story in mind and uses mechanics to move through it. Procedure-enabled play starts with a character, a situation, and structured tools, and lets the story emerge from what those tools generate. *Loner* belongs to the second category. The scene types, the Twist Counter, the Oracle's modifiers: these are not there to tell you what happens. They are there to create the conditions in which something unexpected becomes inevitable.

Playing this way means accepting that the trail only becomes visible when you look back. At the start of a session, you cannot see the arc. After three or four sessions, patterns emerge: a recurring antagonist, a relationship under strain, a goal that has quietly transformed into something else. That arc was never planned. It was discovered, scene by scene, through following what the Oracle made true.

Letting Go of Preconceptions

The hardest habit to break is planning where the story should go. In *Loner*, the story does not have a destination you are working toward. It has a protagonist with a goal, and the Oracle keeps complicating their attempts to reach it.

- **Start each scene open**: Know what your protagonist wants; don't know how the scene ends. The outcome belongs to the Oracle's answers and your protagonist's actions, not to you in advance.
- **Take the Oracle's surprises seriously**: A **Yes, but...** or **No, and...** is the story making a claim. Follow it where it leads, even off the path you expected.

Building the Story as You Go

- **Each scene changes what is true**: A relationship, a resource, a plan, a belief, something shifts every time. Connect the new state to what came before; that connection is what turns events into a story.
- **Let character arcs emerge**: A **Yes, and...** can reveal a strength you didn't know your protagonist had. A **No, but...** can expose a vulnerability. Neither is planned. Follow what the fiction shows you and update the sheet to match.
- **Treat Twists as turning points**: A Twist is a structural shift, not a complication to absorb and move past. Name what changed, a new adversary, a revealed truth, an ally who wasn't who they claimed, and let it alter the protagonist's situation, not just the scene.
- **Let Goals change**: A protagonist whose Goal shifts twice in a campaign hasn't failed; they've responded to a story that moved. When the fiction makes the original Goal obsolete, revise it and write down what caused the change. That reason is the story.

Bringing Twists and Surprises into the Story

Twists are the mechanism by which *Loner* forces the story off its current path. They happen when the Twist Counter reaches 3, signaling a structural shift: a new challenge, a revealed motive, a changed situation. Knowing how to handle

them keeps the story from stalling when everything goes as expected.

Making the Most of the Twist Counter

The mechanics are covered under "Making Decisions Through the Oracle": each equal-dice roll adds 1, at 3 a Twist fires and the counter resets. This section is about what to do with a Twist once it lands.

- **Building Anticipation**: A rising counter is a promise. Let the pressure in your narration climb along with it, so the Twist, when it arrives, isn't the first sign anything was wrong.
- **Timing Twists Thoughtfully**: The counter tells you *when*; you still choose *where* in the scene. Ending on a Twist maximizes its impact; landing one mid-scene is more disruptive. Pick on purpose.

Generating and Integrating Twists

Roll 2d6 and consult the Twist Table for a prompt, *An unexpected ally appears*, *The goal changes*, and treat it as a starting point rather than an instruction.

- **Adapting the Twist to the Scene**: A prompt like *An encounter hinders the Protagonist* isn't the setback; it's a slot for one. An ally reveals a hidden agenda, or an old rival reappears, whichever grows out of what's already true here.
- **Creating Defining Moments**: Let a twist like *A new object or clue changes the scene* actually reframe what the protagonist thought they knew. A twist that changes nothing wasn't a twist.

- **Balancing Surprise with Continuity**: Root twists in fiction that was already unsettled: an NPC whose motives were never quite clear, a location already under pressure. The Twist Table supplies the what; the existing fiction supplies the why.

Developing Characters and Relationships

The people your protagonist meets have motives, histories, and potential to change the story. Developing NPCs and the relationships between them is what gives your protagonist's choices real stakes: the kind that come from caring what happens to specific people, not just abstract outcomes.

Letting NPCs Evolve Over Time

An NPC that seems straightforward at first doesn't have to stay that way; allies, rivals, mentors, and ambiguous figures all respond to what happens around them.

- **Shifting Motivations**: A loyal ally can start questioning your protagonist after a betrayal. A longstanding enemy can reveal a vulnerability when cornered. When something significant happens, ask whether it changes what the NPC wants, and update their tags if it does.
- **Revisiting Key Characters**: An NPC who reappears should carry the weight of the last encounter. A rival comes back with changed goals; an ally returns with news that complicates the plan. That's what makes recurring characters feel like the world remembers.
- **Using Tags to Reflect Change**: *Reluctant Ally* becomes *Trusted Confidant* once a bond is earned, or *Betrayed Associate* once it breaks. The tag itself is the record of what happened.

Relationship Tags

The Core Rules give this mechanic a formal name: a **relationship tag**. It works like any other tag, when it bears directly on the situation, it grants Advantage or Disadvantage on the oracle roll.

The key distinction is how it's acquired. You don't assign relationship tags during character creation; you earn them in play. A bond must be tested, strained, or deepened through actual events before it deserves a tag. *Trusted Informant* isn't a fact about a character, it's a claim that has been proven.

When you update an NPC's tag to reflect a relationship shift, write it as specifically as the fiction allows. *Uneasy Ally* is better than *Ally*; *Sworn Enemy After the Dockside Betrayal* is better still, even if you only use it on the sheet for a session or two. The specificity reminds you why the relationship is what it is, which matters when the NPC reappears unexpectedly.

Deepening Connections and Adding Tension

A connection, alliance, rivalry, or something messier, gives the Oracle something to put at risk that a stranger wouldn't provide.

- **Building Trust and Loyalty**: Trust accrues from small, specific actions: a shared secret, a risk taken together. What it buys later is an NPC willing to help when it costs them something.
- **Introducing Conflict and Personal Stakes**: The sharpest conflicts aren't battles; they're an ally who questions your protagonist's methods, forcing a choice that cuts against what they claim to value.
- **Exploring Emotional Complexity**: A trusted ally turning on your protagonist reads as real only when it comes from desperation or fear, not malice invented to raise the stakes.

- **Letting Relationships Drive the Story**: A plea for help, an adversary's vendetta, treat these as active pressure, not backstory sitting inert on the page.

NPCs Between Scenes

The Meanwhile rule handles antagonists: when the scene mood calls for it, the story cuts away to show the opposition advancing. But allies, contacts, and wildcards exist between scenes too, and the game gives no guidance on what they're doing while the protagonist is occupied elsewhere.

The simplest approach: when a tracked NPC hasn't appeared for a session or two, ask a single Oracle question before the next scene begins, not about what they did in precise detail, but about their current state. *Is Tobias still in the city?* or *Has the Naturalist Order made a move while I was gone?* A Yes or No (with modifiers) is enough to determine whether they're a resource, a complication, or a changed quantity when they next appear.

For allies and contacts in particular, consider their last known motivation and ask whether circumstances have pressure-tested it. A *Loyal Informant* tag is a claim, not a guarantee. If the story has moved significantly since you last checked in, that loyalty may have been strained or deepened, either of which is more interesting than unchanged. Update the tag if the oracle suggests it.

This doesn't need to happen every scene. Reserve it for NPCs who matter and for gaps long enough that the world plausibly moved without you.

Fictional Positioning in Practice

Understanding Your Character's Place in the Story

Fictional positioning means your protagonist's actions follow from who they are and what the scene has already established, not from what you'd like to happen next. Wanting to do something isn't enough; the fiction has to support it.

Aligning Actions with Character Traits

Traits, skills, frailties, and motives aren't decoration; they're what a choice has to run through before it reaches the table.

- **Let Traits Guide Decisions**: *Stealthy* favors the cautious route; *Impulsive* jumps in without checking. The trait doesn't just flavor the choice, it's the reason one option occurs to the character before another does.
- **Embrace Frailties to Add Tension**: *Fear of Heights* stalls a character on a rooftop; *Easily Distracted* costs them the detail that mattered. A frailty is an obstacle that makes the eventual success worth something.
- **Use Goals and Motives as a Compass**: A protagonist driven by *Protecting a Loved One* will sacrifice their own interest for that person's safety, and the choice reads as earned because it came from the motive, not the plot's convenience.

Shaping the World Through Your Character's Actions

Your protagonist doesn't just react to a static world; their choices leave marks on it. Fictional positioning is what makes those marks specific instead of interchangeable.

- **Engage with the Setting**: *Technically Skilled* disables the security system or repairs the machinery that stumps everyone else. The tag is what makes that interaction belong to this character and no other.
- **Influence NPC Relationships**: *Charismatic* opens doors; *Gruff* closes them. NPCs read your protagonist's traits and respond differently because of them, not because the scene requires an obstacle.
- **Generate Consequences with Every Action**: Acting on a frailty like *Reckless* costs something specific: a setback, a strained alliance. Acting on a skill earns something specific in return. Either way, the world remembers what your protagonist did, not just that they acted.

Organic Growth: How Tags Evolve

Tags in *Loner* are not permanent labels. They are claims about what is currently true in the fiction, and fiction changes.

A tag that was true at character creation may become false by the middle of the first adventure. A skill that didn't exist at the start may be the most important thing about the character by the end. This evolution is not handled by a leveling system or experience points. It happens the same way everything in *Loner* happens: by reading what the fiction tells you, and updating the record to match.

Condition Tags Come and Go

Condition tags (*Wounded Leg, Feared by Locals, Hunted*) are temporary by design. They represent states that the fiction imposed, not permanent traits. Remove a condition tag when the fiction no longer supports it: the wound heals over a quiet scene, the fear fades as the protagonist's reputation shifts, the hunt ends when the antagonist changes target.

There is no mechanical procedure for this. You don't roll to clear a condition. You ask whether the fictional state has changed, and if it has, update the tag. If you're unsure whether enough time or effort has passed, ask the oracle: *Has the wound healed enough to stop being a factor?* A Yes of any kind removes the tag. A No means it stays.

Character Growth Emerges from Play

The Core Rules allow you to add, modify, or remove character tags after an adventure. In practice, this means noticing when the fiction has made an old tag obsolete and when a new one has been earned.

What this isn't: accumulation. *Loner* doesn't track improvement with numbers or levels. What it tracks is transformation. The question isn't "how much more capable has this character become?" but "how have they changed?" Sometimes a character ends a campaign more capable than they began. Sometimes they end smaller. Sometimes they stop, unfinished but different. All three are valid arcs, and none requires a scoring system to matter.

Growth in *Loner* comes from friction. A failed scene, a Quiet moment of reckoning, a Meanwhile reveal that changes what the protagonist knows, a single Oracle answer that reframes the situation: these are the triggers. When something shifts in the fiction, the sheet changes to match. Not because a rule demands it, but because the fiction does. This kind of evolution doesn't need points. It needs attention: a willingness to notice when something has shifted and to update the record accordingly.

Your protagonist has been *Shadow Walker* since character creation. After an adventure where they spent three sessions operating in broad daylight and learned to be visible, confi-

dent, and forceful, that tag may no longer fit who they are. Replace it with something that reflects who they became. The lost tag isn't a loss; it's a record that they changed.

The same logic applies to frailties. *Afraid of Confined Spaces* is a legitimate frailty until the protagonist works through it, slowly, across multiple scenes, and it simply isn't true anymore. At that point, remove it or transform it into something subtler: *Tense in Tight Quarters* is softer, but still real.

At the end of a long campaign, your character sheet may have fewer tags than it started with: some crossed out, some rewritten, some left unresolved.

Tags as Beliefs, Not Stats

Tags are claims about who your protagonist believes themselves to be. *Shadow Walker* is not only a skill entry; it is a statement about how this person moves through the world and what they think they are capable of. That statement can become false.

This is the mechanism of character development in *Loner*, and it arrives quietly. No dice roll announces it. You simply reach a moment where you look at a tag and realize it no longer describes what is true in the fiction. The protagonist who was *Afraid of Confined Spaces* spent three sessions working in tight quarters and stopped flinching. The one who carried *Loyal to the Guild* made a choice that severed that loyalty completely.

The mechanism has a cause: scenes create pressure. A Dramatic Scene puts your protagonist against something they cannot ignore. A Quiet scene gives them space to notice what changed. A Meanwhile scene shows the world moving without them. Over enough scenes, this rhythm bends tags.

A relationship tilts. A goal loses its urgency. The character who was *Hard-Eyed Bounty Hunter* begins to hesitate where they once acted, and the tag holds for a while because you hold onto it, but eventually it feels wrong. That is the moment drift becomes visible: not a decision you made, but something you noticed.

When you recognize that a tag has become false, you have two options:

- **Alter it**: Soften, shift, or reframe it into something that reflects what is actually true now. *Afraid of Confined Spaces* might become *Tense in Tight Quarters*: still real, but no longer the same weight.
- **Cancel it**: Remove the tag and write what replaced it, or leave the space blank if nothing has filled it yet.

Neither is failure. The contradiction between who a character was and who they have become is the story. A tag that got scratched out and replaced is a record of something that happened, not evidence of a mistake. The visible residue on the sheet, the crossed-out entry, the revised frailty, tells the character's history in a way that clean, undisturbed tags cannot.

The same logic applies in reverse. A new tag is earned when the fiction makes it obvious. If your protagonist has been operating for three sessions as someone who improvises under pressure, reads situations quickly, and trusts instinct over planning, then *Sharp-Eyed Street Reader* or whatever phrase fits your fiction is already true. Write it down.

What to Ask After Each Adventure

At the end of an adventure, before updating your character sheet, ask:

- **What did this story prove about who they are?** If a tag was never once relevant, it may not be a real part of the character.
- **What did they become that they weren't before?** If a new tag is obvious from the events, write it down.
- **What is no longer true?** A tag that the fiction has contradicted, outgrown, or resolved should be updated or removed.

Growth in *Loner* is the natural consequence of a protagonist who lived through something. Let the story dictate the sheet, not the other way around.

Interacting with the Game World

Social, physical, and mental encounters each call on different tags, but what decides which ones apply, and which direction they tilt the dice, is always the fiction.

Tackling Social, Physical, and Mental Challenges

Social, physical, and mental challenges call on different tags, but the same question decides all three: does the fiction give this character footing to attempt it, and which way does that tilt the dice?

- **Social Challenges**: Persuasion, intimidation, reading someone's intentions, all contests of positioning. *Charismatic*, *Empathetic*, or *Blunt* decide whether your protagonist has the footing to try at all, and which way the dice lean.
- **Physical Challenges**: Sneaking, climbing, fighting. *Stealthy*, *Strong*, or *Quick* establish what's attemptable, and the environment gets a vote too: a *Collapsed Floor* matters as much as *Athletic* when both are in play.

- **Mental Challenges**: Puzzles, strain, quick thinking under pressure. *Logical*, *Sharp-Eyed*, or *Calm Under Pressure* help; *Impatient* or *Easily Distracted* work against them.

Using Tags for Advantage and Disadvantage

The mechanics were explained in "Making Decisions Through the Oracle." The fictional-positioning question is when to apply them: not when the dice say you can, but when the fiction says you should.

- **Playing to Strengths with Advantage**: A situation that aligns with a positive tag earns an extra **Chance Die**. *Persuasive* in a negotiation, *Resilient* under physical strain.
- **Acknowledging Weaknesses with Disadvantage**: A frailty or hostile condition that bears on the action earns an extra **Risk Die**. *Self-Doubt* under pressure, *Physically Frail* when strength decides it.
- **Thinking Creatively with Tags**: A tag's obvious use isn't its only one. *Observant* covers a room's mood as easily as a hidden detail; *Street-Savvy* might extend to institutional politics if the logic actually holds. The test is always whether the claim is true for this character, here.

Impacting the Narrative

Every choice your protagonist makes affects relationships, changes what is true in the world, and shapes who they are. This section covers how to recognize those moments and act on them.

Recognizing Opportunities for Growth

The mechanics of tag evolution are covered in "Organic Growth: How Tags Evolve." This is the practical side: what kinds of moments signal that evolution is due. Growth isn't

planned; it's noticed, after the fact, in setbacks, interactions, and quiet scenes.

- **Learning from Setbacks**: A failed plan, a lost ally, an unwelcome twist, none of these end the story. What your protagonist does next, adapt, dig in, change course, is what growth looks like. They don't grow because they always succeed; they grow because they keep going.
- **Relationships as Catalysts**: NPCs work as mirrors and foils. An ally can push your character to be better or tempt them to compromise. A rival can force them to confront something about themselves they'd rather not.
- **Embracing Reflection**: A quiet scene is where your protagonist takes stock: what changed, what doubt or hope surfaced. That's what turns a choice into a lasting consequence instead of a forgotten beat.

Scars and Losses Are Growth Too

The rules tell you that after a significant moment, you *may* update your protagonist's tags to reflect what they've experienced. That word, *may*, tends to pull players toward gains: a new skill earned, a strength revealed, a relationship forged. But the same rule equally invites the opposite.

A permanent scar is advancement. A lost contact, a broken belief, a frailty that deepens, these are not failures of the narrative; they are the narrative. Your protagonist is not the same person they were at the start, and that change doesn't have to be upward. A character who emerges from a long campaign without any wounds, physical, relational, or moral, has probably not been fully tested.

When a significant setback occurs, ask not just "what did they gain from this?" but "what did they lose, and does that loss deserve to be permanent?" If the answer is yes, write

it down. A new frailty, a replaced skill, a goal that no longer makes sense: these count as much as any victory. Name them.

Making Choices

A choice follows from who the protagonist is, what they want, and what the Oracle has made true, or it doesn't, and that mismatch is worth noticing too.

- **Aligning with Goals and Motives**: Does this decision advance the long-term goal, or drift from it? A choice that follows from motive feels earned; one that contradicts it needs a reason, or it reads as arbitrary.
- **Balancing Relationships**: Helping an ally costs time or resources. Chasing the goal strains a relationship. Let the tradeoff land instead of resolving it painlessly.
- **Weighing Risks and Rewards**: A dangerous shortcut, a fight with a stronger opponent, trusting someone who has reason to betray you, how your protagonist weighs these tells you what they actually value, not just what they say they value.
- **Adapting to Twists**: A Twist changes the story's state. Ask what it does to your protagonist's position, not just to their next action.

Balancing Story and Mechanics

Keeping Mechanics Simple and Intuitive

Mechanics in *Loner* serve the story or they don't belong. Fewer rolls and less rule-checking mean more time in the fiction and less time managing the system.

Minimal Dice Rolling

Dice come out for pivotal moments: tension, risk, a decision with real consequences.

- **Dice for Key Decisions**: Roll only where the outcome isn't obvious and could redirect the story. A roll that doesn't matter yet still gets rolled is just noise.
- **The Oracle Keeps It Simple**: A yes/no answer, occasionally sharpened by **and...** or **but...**, resolves a question in one roll. No calculation stands between the dice and the next beat.
- **Interpretation Over Precision**: The outcome is a claim to interpret, not a number to compute. What makes sense in the fiction decides more than any arithmetic would.

Rules at a Glance

The rules are built to be remembered, not looked up.

- **Concise Core Mechanics**: Oracle responses, Twist Counter, Advantage and Disadvantage, that's the whole vocabulary, and none of it needs a page reference mid-scene.
- **Handy Visual Aids**: The Twist Table and similar quick-reference tools exist for the rare moment you do need to check something, not as a substitute for knowing the rules.

Using Harm and Luck in Conflicts

Conflicts are where the stakes turn concrete. The **Harm and Luck** system keeps them quick: Luck absorbs harm until it runs out, and then the fiction's consequences are no longer optional.

Understanding Conflict Resolution

A conflict resolves through your protagonist's actions, not through drawn-out exchanges. Each roll answers a question about what they're attempting, and the pace stays quick because nothing else is happening.

- **Player-Facing Rolls**: The Oracle answers questions about your protagonist's attempts, never the opposition's. A multi-action conflict might mean several rolls, but each one still centers on their choices and skills, not a simulated exchange of blows.
- **Using Tags for Edge**: A strength earns **advantage** through an extra **Chance Die**; a harsh condition or exploited weakness earns **disadvantage** through an extra **Risk Die**, exactly as in any other challenge.
- **Luck as a Buffer**: Luck absorbs harm and represents a knack for dodging serious consequences. As it drains, so does that knack, until there's nothing left standing between your protagonist and whatever hits them next.

Applying Damage and Consequences

When your protagonist takes Harm, it impacts their Luck first. Once Luck is gone, the narrative consequences ramp up, giving conflicts a real sense of urgency while keeping bookkeeping light.

- **Resolving Harm with Luck**: The damage ladder is in the Core Rules: stronger answers deal more Luck damage to the opponent, worse answers cost the protagonist more, and nothing lands in between. The shape of the ladder is the point. Every roll moves the conflict in one direction or the other; there is no null result, so a conflict under Harm and Luck cannot stall. It can only escalate toward someone's zero.
- **When Luck Runs Out**: When your protagonist's Luck hits zero, the conflict has a conclusion. Stop rolling and ask what the fiction demands: capture, retreat, concession, exposure. This is not death by default. It is a turning point.

Luck Is Not Hit Points

The most common instinct when learning *Loner* is to treat Luck like a health bar: a pool that empties as you get hurt and fills when you heal. That instinct is understandable, but it leads to confusion.

Luck measures how long your protagonist can keep the upper hand in a conflict. That is why it resets fully after every conflict, regardless of what happened. (This behavior is unchanged from the third edition.) A fight that nearly kills your protagonist and a fight they breeze through both end with Luck back at 6. The difference is not in the numbers, but in the tags.

Luck tracks who wins this conflict. Tags track what it cost them.

When a consequence from losing Luck has lasting narrative weight, it becomes a tag. A tag like *Injured*, *Shaken*, or *Rattled* persists into future scenes and does what all tags do: it imposes Disadvantage when it is relevant to the action. That is the mechanism the rules intend for lasting harm. Not a

depleted resource that carries over, but a descriptive condition that reshapes the fiction.

This means you can build a natural escalation without any house rules. A brawl that goes badly might leave your protagonist *Hurt*. Push forward without recovery and the next loss makes it *Injured*. Push further and it becomes *Overcome*. The same pattern works for any conflict type: *Rattled* to *On the Back Foot* to *Humiliated* in a social confrontation, *Spooked* to *Paranoid* to *Broken* after repeated psychological pressure.

These progressions are not prescribed by the system. They emerge from the fiction. The system's job is to make the Oracle's answers land in the story; your job is to name what they leave behind.

- **Tailoring Consequences to the Conflict**: Exhaustion or injury in a physical struggle; reputation damage or a lost alliance in a social one; exposure or a burned safe house in a chase. Name the specific cost, and the tag will carry more weight than a generic one ever could.

Frailties and Opponent Weaknesses in Conflict

Frailties in conflict reduce to two cases: your own bears on the exchange and costs you Disadvantage, or you identify and exploit an opponent's and earn Advantage. The question behind both is the same one from "Fictional Positioning in Practice": *Who holds the better position in the fiction right now?*

Prioritizing Narrative Flow

A streamlined system only pays off if you actually let it stay out of the way. Simple decision-making and quick conflict

resolution mean the story moves without a mechanical detour.

Avoiding Overcomplication

Complex mechanics and excess detail are what stall a story, not too few rules.

- **Streamlined Decisions and Rolls**: Consult the Oracle only when the outcome is genuinely uncertain or high-stakes. A roll that doesn't meet that bar isn't building tension, it's delaying the scene.
- **Context-Driven Interpretations**: A **Yes, but...** doesn't need a subsystem to resolve, just a complication that makes sense in the scene you're already in.
- **Limit Scope of Questions**: A string of questions about one situation manufactures detail nobody asked for. Make the judgment call, or read one answer generously, and move the scene forward.

Letting Story Moments Develop

Every scene is an opportunity to show what your protagonist values, how they respond under pressure, and what the world costs them. Protecting that space from mechanical clutter is the whole point of keeping rules light.

- **Give key scenes room**: Big decisions, confrontations, and emotionally charged moments deserve attention. If your protagonist is making a choice that affects a core relationship or goal, let it develop fully rather than resolving it in a single oracle roll.
- **Use Twists as turning points**: When a Twist occurs, do not absorb it and move on. Ask what changed in the protagonist's situation. A Twist that leaves everything essentially the same was not really a twist.

- **Balance action with quieter scenes**: The Scene Transition roll already does some of this work. When you get a Quiet Scene, use it. Let the protagonist reflect, plan, or sit with what just happened. Those scenes make the action scenes land harder.
- **Vary the rhythm**: Consecutive dramatic scenes can be exhausting and flattening. The tension-and-release pattern the Scene Transition roll creates is not arbitrary: it keeps individual scenes distinct rather than blurring together.

Enhancing Solo Play Experience

Techniques for Presence

Solo play works best when you feel present in the fiction, not watching it from outside. Atmosphere, mood, and visualization are how you get there.

Creating Atmosphere and Mood

A scene whose mood you've set before the first roll is a scene whose oracle answers you can actually read.

- **Sensory Details**: The noise, the smell, the press of bodies in a market, put them in your head before you ask a question. A vague setting produces a vague answer; a specific one gives the dice something to bite into.

- **Setting the Emotional Tone**: Anticipation, dread, unease, quiet, decide the register before you roll. A **Yes, but…** in a tense scene reads differently than the same result in a calm one.
- **Background Sounds or Music**: Whatever holds the scene in your head while you play, forest ambiance, city noise, a soundtrack, use it.

Visualization and "Theater of the Mind"

"Theater of the Mind" means enough visual specificity that decisions feel real, not elaborate prose. The scene needs to be concrete enough to answer a question, nothing more.

- **Think in images**: A close-up on your protagonist's expression, a wide shot of the facility they're about to enter. A concrete image resolves an abstract oracle answer; a vague one doesn't.
- **Internal monologue**: You're both storyteller and protagonist. What does the character notice that no one else would? What are they afraid to admit? That's what makes them this character and not a stand-in.
- **Slow down for key moments**: A confrontation, a discovery, a quiet reckoning, these earn more than a single roll and a scene change. Let them take the time they need.

Journaling and Record-Keeping

Loner is often described as a journaling game, but that framing is misleading. Journaling is one way to play it. It is not required, and the system does not assume it.

The Sheet as Journal

The character sheet already accumulates a record of what happened. Crossed-out tags, revised frailties, new gear replacing old, relationship tags earned and lost: these marks

tell the story of the protagonist without a single sentence of prose. If you play through a dozen sessions and do nothing but update the sheet honestly after each one, you will have a legible chronicle of what changed and what it cost.

Emotional weight in *Loner* comes from friction in play, from following where the Oracle leads and living with what it produces. That weight lives in the fiction, not in the writing about it afterward. A scratched-out tag carries the same story that a journal paragraph would, and it takes five seconds.

If the character sheet is your only record, the minimum habit is this: after each session, check every tag and update anything that the fiction changed. Then note the current Goal and the single most important thing that happened. That is enough to return to the story cleanly.

If You Want to Write

Some players find that writing during or after a session deepens their engagement. If that is you, the following practices keep records useful rather than burdensome:

- **Scene Summaries**: A few lines after each scene covering the major events, oracle outcomes, and any tag changes. This is the minimum. It takes two minutes and prevents three sessions of confusion.
- **Character and Relationship Logs**: Track your protagonist and significant NPCs separately. Record tag changes, motivation shifts, and the current state of key relationships. When an NPC reappears, you want to know who they are now, not who they were when they were introduced.
- **Goal and Motivation Updates**: When your protagonist's goal shifts, write down what caused it. The reason is as important as the new direction.

- **Key Moments**: Note the scenes that felt significant: a choice made under pressure, a loss, a moment where the protagonist became someone slightly different. These are what give the story shape when you look back at it.
- **Visual Elements**: Maps, relationship diagrams, sketches of key characters or locations: optional, but they make the world feel more specific and easier to return to after a break.

The test for any record is simple: can you pick up the game after two weeks away and know where you are? If yes, the record is doing its job, whatever form it takes.

Managing Pace and Tension

The three scene types (Dramatic, Quiet, and Meanwhile) were introduced in "Scene Structure and Flow." This chapter covers how to use each one well: what each type demands of the protagonist, and how the rhythm between them keeps the story alive. In *Loner*, pacing comes from the alternation of dramatic and quiet scenes. The Scene Transition roll handles this mechanically, but understanding why it matters helps you make the most of each scene type.

Balancing Dramatic and Quiet Scenes

Alternating between intense and reflective scenes creates a rhythm: the dramatic ones advance the situation, and the quiet ones give the protagonist space to recover.

- **Dramatic scenes build pressure**: These are the moments of conflict, discovery, and forced decision. They advance the situation and raise stakes. Every dramatic scene should leave the protagonist in a different position than they started.
- **Quiet scenes provide recovery and connection**: After a dramatic scene, a quiet scene offers the protagonist space to regroup, plan, or develop relationships. These scenes are not filler: they are where character development happens and where the next dramatic scene is set up.
- **Escalation comes from continuity**: Stakes rise not because each scene is louder than the last, but because the protagonist's position keeps changing. Each scene's outcome feeds into the next. When quiet moments are earned, the dramatic ones hit harder.
- **Turning points don't wait for the roll**: A Quiet Scene can tip into a Dramatic one before the Scene Transition roll. When pressure enters the fiction and the scene's register shifts, that moment is a **turning point**. Close the scene there and open a Dramatic Scene from the point of shift. The transition roll is for scenes that end cleanly; a turning point is when the situation decides for you.

Using the Scene Transition Table

The **Scene Transition table** sets the register for each new scene, ensuring the story flows naturally and keeps tension well-balanced. With a quick roll, you decide whether the upcoming scene will be calm, suspenseful, or urgent.

- **Dramatic Scene**: Conflict, tension, or high stakes. Your protagonist faces pressure, opposition, or a forced decision. Use these scenes to change the situation, not just dramatize it.
- **Quiet Scene**: The pressure lifts. Your protagonist has initiative. Use the space for introspection, relationship development, or preparation. These scenes are what make the dramatic ones feel earned.
- **Meanwhile Scene**: The world moves without the protagonist. Cut to whoever holds power over the situation, update their tags, and ask whether an ally acts independently. This scene type is procedural, not atmospheric: follow the steps the Core Rules describe.

The Scene Transition roll gives you the rhythm. Working with it rather than overriding it keeps the story from becoming a sustained scream.

Tracking Goals Across Sessions

The Goal tag gives your protagonist a direction, but it doesn't tell you how to measure progress toward it, or when you've arrived. In a single session this rarely matters; the story moves fast enough that resolution feels natural. Across multiple sessions, without any scaffolding, a Goal can drift from anchor to background decoration.

A practical approach: treat your protagonist's Goal as a question, not a destination. *Can Zahra expose the Syndicate before they silence her?* is a better working Goal than *Expose the Syndicate* because it implies stakes, a timeframe, and a condition for failure. Each session, ask whether recent events have moved that question closer to a yes or a no, and update the Goal tag when it shifts.

Consider tracking two or three **milestones**: not as formal rules, but as notes to yourself. These are conditions that, if met, would clearly advance the Goal: a key ally gained, a crucial piece of evidence found, a confrontation with the Nemesis survived. Milestones give you a sense of narrative distance without railroading the story. When one lands, mark it and let it reshape the next session's starting question.

Finally, do not wait for the Goal to resolve before asking whether it still fits. A protagonist changed by events may find that their original Goal no longer reflects who they are. That realization, and the choice to revise or abandon it, is itself a significant story moment worth treating as one.

Challenge Tracks and Leverage (optional modules)

Tracking Goals Across Sessions describes the narrative problem. The Core Rules offer a mechanical solution for players who want it: **Challenge Tracks**. Both mechanics are optional: skip them for a lighter game and continue resolving long-term goals through regular oracle questions and narration.

When a Goal is large enough that no single oracle result can resolve it: an investigation spanning multiple sessions, a long journey, a slowly-built conspiracy, open a Challenge Track. The mechanics (four boxes, marked or erased by the oracle result that closes each focused scene) are in the Core Rules. When all four boxes are filled, the challenge resolves as a narrative fact, no final roll required.

Most tracks open with four boxes. For longer arcs that span many sessions, you can open with six instead. Beyond that, difficulty is not something you assign when you open the track: it emerges from the fiction as you play. A grueling

pursuit is one where the oracle keeps answering No, erasing progress and forcing you to work for every box. An easier one is one where the story is generous. You will notice the difference in play without deciding anything in advance.

This connects naturally to the milestones approach described above. Each box represents roughly one milestone-worth of progress. If you've been tracking milestones informally, you can map them directly onto the four boxes and start using the oracle progress rules without changing how you play.

Not every scene updates a Challenge Track. The track only moves when the scene's main action directly engages the challenge: when the oracle question you're asking is directly about the pursuit, not just adjacent to it. A scene where Zahra repairs her gear, or interrogates someone about an unrelated matter, doesn't touch the "Expose the Leton Corporation" track. That's correct. The track records narrative engagement, not session time.

The clearest way to stay honest about this is to use the Framing procedure as your filter. Before a scene opens, you answer three questions, including *What does the Protagonist intend to do here?* If the answer has nothing to do with the challenge, the scene will not update the track, and that's a conscious choice rather than an accidental one. If you notice that several scenes in a row have intentions unrelated to the challenge, that's a signal: the story has drifted. The protagonist is busy, but not on the right trail.

When you want to re-engage the challenge, frame a scene with the intention explicitly pointing at it. That scene, and only that scene, is eligible to move the track. A question

asked in passing during a scene framed around something else does not count, even if the result is dramatic.

Leverage is the companion mechanic; its full rules (one held result, two ways to spend it, expiry by fiction or Twist, and how it interacts with Challenge Track boxes) are in the Core Rules. The habit that makes it work: never write just "Leverage." Write what it actually is: *Full system access*, *Guard's trust earned*, *Knows the safe combination*. The specific phrase is the expiry test. If the current moment no longer connects to those words, the Leverage is already gone, and no rule needs to tell you so.

📌 Example

> Zahra rolls **Yes, and...** while hacking the Leton Corporation terminal. She banks it as *Leverage: full system access*. Three scenes later, facing a locked security door in the same facility, she spends it to add Advantage to the Oracle roll rather than rolling cold. Alternatively, if the door roll comes back **No, and...** (the door holds and an alarm triggers), she can spend the Leverage to convert it to **No, but...**: the door holds, but she spots a maintenance override panel nearby.

Think of Leverage as narrative momentum: a moment where everything went your way, held in reserve for when you need it most.

Ending the Campaign

Loner campaigns do not end when you decide they should. They end when the fiction gives you a signal, and you recognize it.

The clearest signal is Goal resolution: the protagonist achieves their goal, fails in a way that makes it impossible, or arrives at a place where the goal no longer reflects who they are. Any of these is a valid ending. A goal that was achieved feels complete. A goal that became impossible leaves a protagonist changed by the attempt. A goal that was abandoned or transformed marks someone who learned something more important than what they originally wanted.

Other signals are subtler. The Nemesis has been faced, one way or another, and the relationship is resolved. The character sheet has shifted so far from its starting state that the protagonist who began the campaign and the one you are playing now are barely recognizable as the same person. The story has answered the question it was asking, not necessarily cleanly, but completely enough that adding more would be adding noise.

When you feel one of these signals, close the campaign in a final scene. Frame it the same way you frame any scene: where is the protagonist, who is present, and what happens here. Answer the Goal tag one last time: achieved, abandoned, or transformed. Note what has changed on the sheet since the first session. A campaign that ends with a crossed-out skill, a rewritten frailty, and a different Goal than it started with has told a story.

Not every campaign reaches a conclusion. Some stop mid-stride: a player loses interest, life intervenes, the story runs out of steam. This is not failure. A character sheet frozen mid-campaign is itself a record: here is who this person was becoming, and here is where they stopped. That is also a kind of ending.

Advanced Concepts and Customization

Handling Complex Situations

Some scenes call for a light adjustment, or a temporary mechanic the core system doesn't cover. The goal is never complexity for its own sake; it's keeping the fiction from stalling.

Adapting Rules to Fit the Fiction

Solo play produces situations the rules didn't anticipate. Adjust lightly, and only in service of the story.

- **Expanding the Oracle's Range**: A single yes/no can feel too narrow for a scene with several moving parts. Split it: "Does the guard notice?" then "Does he raise the alarm?" instead of one question trying to carry both.
- **Adapting Tags to Context**: *Stealthy* usually means concealment, but in a heist it can extend to quick, quiet hands. Let a tag flex to its context instead of writing a new one.
- **Adjusting Difficulty with Dice Tweaks**: Add or drop a die, or treat a **Yes, but...** as a **Yes, and...** to sharpen a high-risk confrontation. A small tweak, used rarely, raises the stakes without becoming a new subsystem.

Introducing New Mechanics Sparingly

A temporary mechanic earns its place only for the scene it was built for, then it retires.

- **Temporary Rules for Special Situations**: A "timer" to count rounds in a chase, "progress points" for a multi-step puzzle, built for one scene and discarded after.

- **Applying Special Conditions**: *Fatigued* limits physical tags until rest; *Distracted* costs Disadvantage on mental tasks this scene. The condition does the work; nothing else needs to change.
- **Custom Rolls for Narrative Depth**: A "three-roll challenge," two successes out of three, for a high-stakes negotiation. It raises the drama of one pivotal moment without touching what the Oracle does anywhere else.

The test for any of these is the same: does it serve the fiction, or does it just add friction?

Expanding Beyond the Basics

Loner stays simple by default, but it accepts optional elements when a story actually needs one: environmental hazards, resource tracking, relationship systems, custom tags.

Incorporating Additional Game Elements

Add these sparingly, and only when the fiction has created the need for one.

- **Environmental Hazards and Obstacles**: An *Intense Heat* condition in a desert setting saps Luck or adds disadvantage to physical actions. The hazard is a tag like any other; it just comes from the world instead of the character.
- **Resource Management**: If survival matters, track food, water, ammo, nothing more than a note of what's been used. Running low is what pushes a protagonist toward allies or risk, not a spreadsheet.
- **Timed Challenges or Deadlines**: A *countdown* on a crumbling building turns a scene urgent because every action now has a cost measured against the clock, not because urgency was declared.

- **Relationship Trackers**: *Hostile*, *Neutral*, *Ally*, a scale that shifts with what the protagonist does, useful only when an NPC recurs often enough for the shift to matter.

Creating Custom Tags and Traits

- **Unique Protagonist Traits**: *Desert Survivalist* or *Haunted by the Past* earns a scene a reason to happen that *Strong* or *Intelligent* never would.
- **Specialized NPC Tags**: *Streetwise* for an informant, *Grudge Holder* for a nemesis, a tag that names the role rather than the archetype.
- **Object and Location Tags**: *Soulbound* on an artifact, *Haunted Grounds* on a castle, something your protagonist can actually act on, not just atmosphere.
- **Evolving Tags**: *Inexperienced* becomes *Seasoned Fighter* once the fiction has earned it. The tag changing is the record of the character changing.

Custom tags extend *Loner*; they don't replace it. Use one when the story needs it, and let it go when the story moves past it.

Mixing Geared Towards Loner Games

Every title in the *Loner* line shares the same structural core: the same oracle mechanics, the same tag-based characters, the same yes/no cadence. This means the rules are modular. A mechanic from one game can be lifted, renamed, and dropped into another without breaking anything, because the underlying language is identical. The examples below use *Geared Towards Loner* standalone games, but the same technique works with Adventure Packs.

This is useful when a familiar game starts to feel too predictable. The prompts that once surprised you become

expected. The fix is not to abandon the game: it is to cross-pollinate.

The Recipe

1. Pick two *Geared Towards Loner* games.
2. Identify one key mechanic from each: a resource track, a special oracle modifier, a faction system, a condition type.
3. Rename and reskin those mechanics to fit the hybrid's tone.
4. Roll oracles. Let the combination generate something neither game would produce alone.

The tags change to fit the new fiction. The oracle does not change at all.

Two Examples

Steam-Tomb Raiders (*Cog & Compass* + *Dungeoneer*): Victorian scholars and brass-gear mercenaries delve into ruins beneath the city, unlocking deathtraps with pneumatic gadgets. Take *Dungeoneer*'s Mana resource and rename it *Pressure*, tracking the strain on prototype tools rather than magical reserves. Keep *Cog & Compass*'s political engine and steampunk tags as the outer-world layer. The result is a game with two distinct zones of tension: the delve below and the faction intrigue above.

Haunted Knights of Avalon (*Legends of Camelot* + *Kwaidan!*): A knight's virtue is tested not by foes but by yokai guardians haunting the ruins of an old Grail site. Run *Legends of Camelot*'s Honour Tests and *Kwaidan!*'s Fear Tokens side by side. Failed Honour opens the character to Possession by spirits. The two mechanics reinforce each other: chivalric pressure becomes vulnerability to the supernatural,

and the supernatural makes chivalric pressure dangerous. Neither game alone produces that dynamic.

The pattern is consistent across any combination: find the mechanic in each game that produces the most friction, name them clearly so they feel distinct, and let the oracle adjudicate between them.

Personalizing Your Adventure

Loner is designed to flex around your preferences. You can adjust the mechanics, emphasize certain aspects of play, and explore different genres without breaking the system. The core mechanic stays the same; everything around it can be shaped to fit how you like to tell stories.

Tailoring the Game to Your Preferences

Some players are here for introspection, others for conflict, others for building a world. *Loner* doesn't rank these; it just asks you to adjust the mechanics to whichever one you're actually doing.

- **Adjusting Mechanics for Pacing**: Chasing speed, skip the rolls that don't matter and let intuition carry the rest. Chasing texture, add steps to conflict resolution or a mini-challenge inside a scene. Same system, different throttle.
- **Emphasizing Character Growth**: Milestones that unlock or refine a trait turn development into something visible on the sheet, not just a feeling you had about the character.
- **Focusing on Relationships**: A simple tracker on how NPCs react over time is enough to make each encounter carry weight instead of resetting to neutral every scene.

- **Adapting Difficulty for Story Themes**: A story of endurance wants limited resources and harsh conditions; a story of discovery wants clues and revelation ahead of conflict. Match the difficulty to what the story is actually about.

Experimenting with Different Genres

Switching genres changes the tags, the setting logic, the questions worth asking. The Oracle itself doesn't move.

Fantasy hands the Oracle to fate or divine will, and a *Dragon Slayer* or *Mage's Apprentice* to the sheet. Science fiction hands it to an AI or a networked intelligence, and swaps in *Starship Pilot* or *Cybernetic Enhancements*. In horror, the Oracle seeds ominous presence and the Twist Counter is let to build slowly toward *Paranormal Sensitivity* or *Survivor Instincts* paying off. A period piece grounds *Court Etiquette* or *Swordsmanship* in real historical pressure instead of inventing new stakes. Mystery and noir push the Oracle toward discovery: *Observant Detective* or *Black Market Ties* exist to be the tag that finally reads the clue right.

The tags change with the genre. The oracle mechanic underneath them never does, which is the actual test of whether a system is portable rather than just claiming to be.

Appendix A: How Loner Happened

It was the summer of 2019, and I wanted to bring my friends (some of them had never played RPGs before) into a small campaign. For a few years we'd been playing Escape Room board games, but one of us was pregnant, so it wasn't really practical to go out and play them in person anymore.

I started from the assumption that:

- some TTRPGs share traits with escape games
- part of our group had played TTRPGs back in university
- those who hadn't were at least intrigued by the hype around *Stranger Things*

I wanted to ride that wave of interest and rekindle an old passion I'd dropped about ten years earlier, after life got in the way and I lost my old gaming group. I spent a few hours brushing up, but I didn't want to play D&D. I wanted something extremely light. Before long, I fell down the rabbit hole of rules-light games: *Risus*, *Lasers & Feelings*, various one-page RPGs, and of course *Freeform Universal* (FU).

I was almost ready to start, but in the end, nothing actually happened. I ended up buying a copy of *Legends of Andor* instead, hoping to lure my friends and my wife in (take the long way around, so to speak) and gently trap them in a fantasy adventure.

We played one game… and then the pandemic hit. Everyone stuck at home, no board games unless it was on Board Game Arena, and *Andor* definitely wasn't there. So I suggested: why don't we try an RPG session? Everyone enthusiastically agreed. I spent hours looking for something simple enough for everyone, setting up a virtual table on Roll20… and the

session was a complete disaster. Epic, even. The kind of disaster that meant my wife never wanted to hear about RPGs again.

But I had fallen back into the hobby headfirst, and it wasn't going to leave my mind. Since I was supposed to prep "a D&D" (aka a fantasy game), I'd downloaded and read quite a few OSR titles (though at the time I didn't even know that's what they were): *Swords & Six-Siders*, *White Box*, *Basic Fantasy*... In a short time I had built up a sizeable collection. And right in the middle of my prep, Ganesha Games gave away free solidarity copies of *Four Against Darkness*. I tried it out during one of those long lockdown evenings, and I was hooked again. But no one around me wanted to play.

That's how I ended up, though I don't remember exactly how, digging into Solo RPGs. And I didn't just find a new niche. I found a whole universe of people playing alone! It was possible! The more I read and watched, the more tools and rulesets I collected, and the more I wanted to play. Finally, I gathered the courage to run my first session of *White Box*. I had a blast. It was quick, easy, and damn satisfying.

The next obvious step was reading *Mythic GME*. I always say this, but it's worth repeating: all of us solo players owe Tana Pigeon an unpayable debt. Without her, solo RPGs as we know them today simply wouldn't exist. Credit where credit is due.

Among the one-page games I had collected that year, there was this odd cheat sheet called "FU+Mythic." By then I had studied both FU and Mythic in detail, so trying it felt like the natural next step. It was a great workflow for someone who knew both systems, though it really lived in their details. But as much as I respect Mythic, it's just not my cup of tea. Some

of its steps feel overly complicated to me. Not broken, not wrong, just not my way of playing.

Somewhere along the way, I also discovered Matt Jackson's *so1um*. It's a small but wonderful game, deeply rooted in both solo RPG tradition and classic adventure gaming. A real gem. My first instinct was to "fatten it up" a bit, and thanks to its open license I could share it for free as *so1um enhanced*. Mostly I added a 2d6 version of Mythic's meaning tables and a cliché list lifted from TV Tropes. Yes, I've always been terrible at coming up with clichés (to use *Risus* terminology). Other things I needed for *so1um* were an initial scene generator, a bestiary (since *so1um* uses stats), and a slightly more advanced oracle than the base d6 one. Somewhere in the depths of the internet I stumbled on Tiny Solitary Soldiers' oracle (sadly, the blog is now offline), a simplified Mythic that was absolutely perfect for me.

You can see the building blocks taking shape, right?

The thing is, *so1um* still didn't quite fit my style. You see, I hate stats. Sure, I can play traditional games with numerical attributes (Traveller/Cepheus Engine has them, and it might be my favorite system after FU). But for my solo play... they're a nuisance. I prefer a more qualitative approach. And that's exactly where FU shines: tag-based, organic character growth, d6-based... just perfect. I honestly think it's one of the most brilliant TTRPGs ever made. Easy to play, easy to explain. Maybe not the most intuitive if you're coming straight from traditional RPGs, but that wasn't my concern. I was playing alone!

The other condition I wanted to meet was playing with a single character. OSR-style games don't scale down well (they can, but you need subsystems like Kevin Crawford's *Solo*

Heroes), and I didn't want to run a party. Nor was I particularly interested in playing endless dungeon crawls (I'm not a big fan, as you've probably gathered by now).

So I had a good framework from my *so1um* tweaks. A handy "first scene" suggestion (start in the middle of the action) straight from *so1um*. FU as a tag-based, oracle-driven system. The pieces were starting to align.

One thing was missing: I wanted to play literally anywhere. FU can build fairly large dice pools, meaning you need to carry two full sets of d6s. But right around then, Graven Utterance released *Recluse*, which produced the same results as the FU oracle but only needed four dice (two pairs in different colors). That was the missing piece. Now I had my core rules:

- A character defined by tags
- A portable resolution roll
- An oracle for twists and scene transitions
- A basic adventure generator
- A first-scene framing tool

With the help of TV Tropes, I made my first character, Zahra Nakajima, and played my first session with this Frankenstein system. And yes, the example session in *Loner* 1e was real. I still have Zahra's sheet pinned to my whiteboard, right here in front of me.

The first playtests of that cobbled-together system were satisfying, but combat was a pain in the ass. That's always been FU's weak spot for me: resolving fights through a string of questions.

But there was an important lesson I'd picked up from the *Risus Companion*, what S. John Ross calls the *unholy trinity*: Single-Action Contest, Combat, Target Number Roll. And the

key reminder that not every conflict is combat. Crucial. I didn't have TNs, but the notion of Single-Action Contests was really helpful: it let me resolve anything in one question if I wanted. What I still needed was a middle ground: a way to play with a slightly gamey feel without sinking into tactical sludge.

Once again, the open FU community came to the rescue. At the time I was looking into *TWERPS*, a goofy little game built around a single stat that also doubled as HP, capped at 5. While I was figuring out how to apply that idea, Chaosmeister released the *6Q System*, complete with Luck and a Harm system. Exactly what I needed! I added a Luck trait to Zahra, dropped the 6Q table into my draft, and it worked like a charm. Suddenly I had a cohesive game, stitched together from bits and pieces, and it played beautifully. So why not share it?

I finalized the draft, did some quick typesetting, and published it for free on itch.io and DriveThruRPG. It got a good number of downloads. I was happy to have given something back to the gaming community. That was it.

Or so I thought.

About a year and a half later, in a small Italian Telegram group, someone asked me about solo RPGs. Up to that point, I had only ever faced mockery, resistance, or disbelief about the idea. So I wasn't keen on talking. I kept playing on my own, with the occasional online session or convention game I'd managed to set up. But this unexpected conversation sparked real curiosity in a handful of people. We split off into a separate group to talk about it more. The discussion was fruitful, and soon they asked me if we could play something

simple together. I told them: well, there's *Loner*... maybe I could translate it for you.

But here's the thing: Italian isn't as elliptical as English. You can be concise and clear in English; in Italian, not so much. And on top of that, the paradigm was way too far from D&D to be instantly grasped. They bombarded me with questions. The more I answered, the thicker the draft grew. Then they wanted diagrams. Then more examples. Then more clarifications. Within three weeks, I had *Loner* 2e in my hands. And it was good. So I translated it back into English. That's why *Loner* 2e seemed "odd" to some. *Loner* 1e was written directly in English. Its Italian translation became the heart of 2e. Then I translated that back into English. Lost in translation... (Italian is a cursed language to translate back from).

And that's the real story of how *Loner* ended up on your table. Sure, I could add the last couple of years too... but that would just get boring and deeply technical. And you don't really care about that part.

License

Loner 4e: Companion

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